

give their opinion on all of it. Not every decision can be explained or needs to be. At some point, some people's job is just to answer the phones, to press the buttons, to shred the documents, to argue in court, because that's what they are paid to do. They are paid to do a job.

But that's the nice thing about lawyers: as long as you're paying them, they're usually good with whatever terms go along with it. Compartmentalization is their job. It's how they represent people who are guilty, how they file long motions they know are unlikely to be successful, how they can patiently keep secrets that they'd otherwise love to be able to share.

Harder was nearly twenty years into his legal career when he was first approached. Though he often worked on celebrity cases they tended to be for routine matters, not exciting criminal proceedings or blockbuster cases, and when you're retained to enforce rights of privacy and publicity on behalf of your clients, it tends to follow that they don't want you grandstanding in the media on their behalf, building a profile as you work for them. His last appearance in the *New York Times* had been in 2001, about a case for a client who had been let go from an ad firm almost immediately after she left her new job to join it. Harder won two months' back pay. It's not exactly the kind of victory that marked the career of lawyers like Marty Singer, whom Harder had once worked for, and whom the *Times* had called the "Guard Dog to the Stars." A lawyer who *had* publicly fought cases over celebrity sex tapes, who tangled with Gawker once on behalf of Rebecca Gayheart and the actor Eric Dane when their tape had run on Gawker and managed to eke out a small settlement, without an admission of guilt. So why not hire Singer? Because Peter Thiel and Mr. A didn't want someone who was content to settle, or another